

SSIS Elementary Language Support Framework Overview

Grade 1-Grade 5 Overview

(updated June 2025)

Purpose

The SSIS EAL Literacy Agreement is designed to provide a comprehensive framework for supporting Emergent and Developing English as an Additional Language Learners (EALs) in their language acquisition journey. By aligning our instructional practices with the WIDA framework and integrating targeted strategies, we aim to enhance the academic success and social integration of EALs within our educational environment.

Rationale

The rationale for establishing the SSIS EAL Literacy Agreement is rooted in the recognition that multilingual learners are valuable contributors to our school community. By fostering an inclusive and supportive learning environment, we aim to:

1. **Promote Equity:** Ensure that all learners, regardless of their language background, have access to high-quality education that meets their unique needs.
2. **Enhance Engagement:** Create engaging and meaningful learning experiences that resonate with EALs, leveraging their cultural backgrounds and prior knowledge.
3. **Support Language Proficiency:** Provide targeted interventions and instruction that facilitate the development of listening, speaking, reading, and writing skills, ultimately leading to academic success.
4. **Encourage Independence:** Empower EALs to become autonomous learners who can effectively navigate their educational journeys and build confidence in their language abilities.

By implementing this agreement, we commit to a collaborative approach that prioritizes the holistic development of our Emergent and Developing EALs, ensuring they are equipped with the language skills necessary to thrive academically and socially.

Emergent and Developing English Language Learners

Emergent and Developing EALs represent critical stages in language acquisition as defined by the WIDA framework. Emergent EALs, typically at the Entering and Emerging proficiency levels, exhibit limited English language skills and may rely heavily on visual supports and contextual clues to understand basic vocabulary and simple sentences. Their ability to engage in conversations is often constrained, but they begin to use isolated words and phrases to communicate. In contrast, Developing EALs, classified at the Developing proficiency levels, demonstrate a growing command of English. These students can form more complex sentences and engage in discussions, though they may still struggle with academic language and may require support in understanding nuanced vocabulary and grammatical structures. Both groups benefit from targeted instruction that builds their language skills while promoting engagement with grade-level content.

WIDA Guiding Principles of Language Development

1. Multilingual learners' languages and cultures are valuable resources to be leveraged for schooling and classroom life; leveraging these assets and challenging biases help develop multilingual learners' independence and encourage their agency in learning.
2. Multilingual learners' development of multiple languages enhances their knowledge and cultural bases, their intellectual capacities, and their flexibility in language use.
3. Multilingual learners' language development and learning occur over time through meaningful engagement in activities that are valued in their homes, schools and communities.
4. Multilingual learners' language, social-emotional, and cognitive development are inter-related processes that contribute to their success in school and beyond.
5. Multilingual learners use and develop language when opportunities for learning take into account their individual experiences, characteristics, abilities, and levels of language proficiency.
6. Multilingual learners use and develop language through activities which intentionally integrate multiple modalities, including oral, written, visual, and kinesthetic modes of communication.
7. Multilingual learners use and develop language to interpret and access information, ideas, and concepts from a variety of sources, including real-life objects, models, representations, and multimodal texts.

8. Multilingual learners draw on their metacognitive, metalinguistic, and metacultural awareness to develop effectiveness in language use.
9. Multilingual learners use their full linguistic repertoire, including translanguage practices, to enrich their language development and learning
10. Multilingual learners use and develop language to interpret and present different perspectives, build awareness of relationships, and affirm their identities

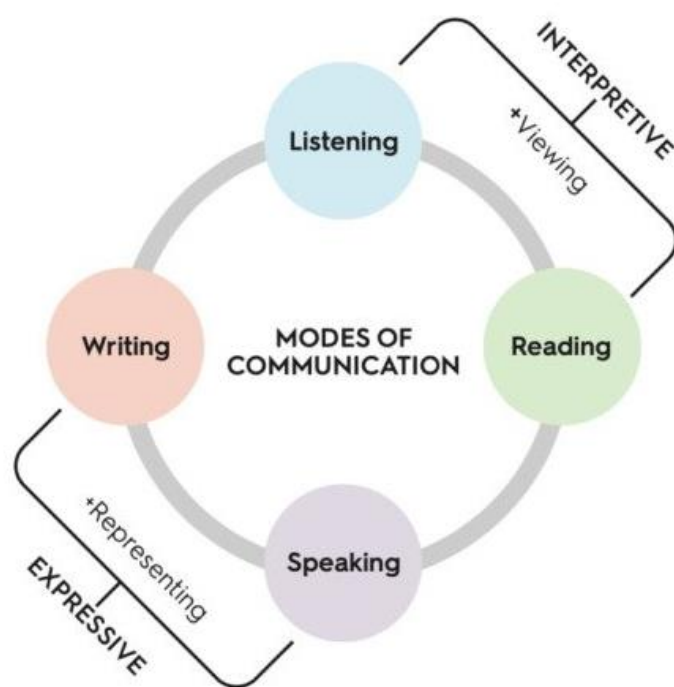
Modes of Communication

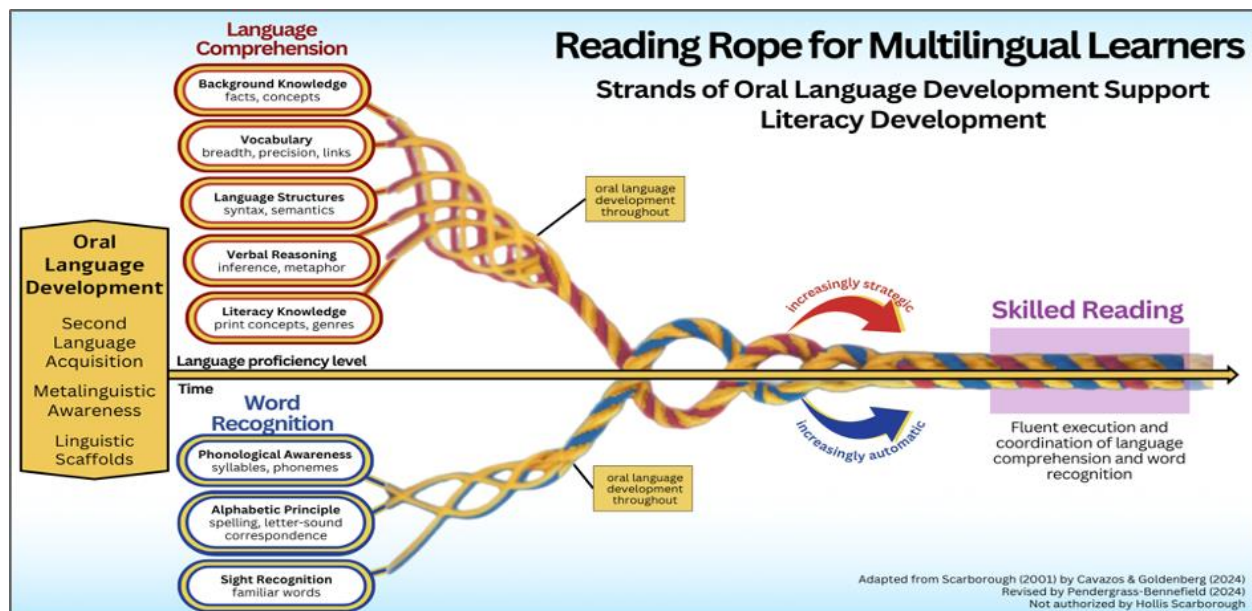
WIDA identifies four modes of communication that are essential for language development in English language learners (ELs). These modes encompass various ways students can engage with language: listening, speaking, reading, and writing.

Listening involves understanding spoken language from various sources, including conversations, lectures, and media. Key skills in this mode include identifying main ideas and supporting details, understanding different accents and dialects, and following oral instructions and directions.

Speaking refers to the ability to express ideas verbally in various contexts, such as informal conversations and formal presentations. Important skills for speaking include using appropriate vocabulary and grammar, organizing thoughts clearly and coherently, and engaging in discussions while responding to questions effectively.

Reading involves interpreting and understanding written texts across different genres and subjects. Skills associated with reading include analyzing texts for meaning, purpose, and audience, employing reading strategies like predicting, summarizing, and questioning, and recognizing text features and structures.





The Reading Rope for Multilinguals Learning is a visual representation of the importance of oral language for reading development.

Writing concerns the ability to communicate ideas effectively through written text, including essays, reports, and creative writing. Key skills in writing involve structuring written work with clear organization, using appropriate language, style, and tone for different audiences, and revising and editing for clarity and correctness.

WIDA emphasizes the integration of these modes of communication in instruction. This holistic approach helps EALs develop their language proficiency more effectively, as skills in one mode support growth in others. Overall, these modes are foundational for academic success and social interaction in English-speaking environments.

WIDA Language Standards

The WIDA language standards provide a framework designed to support the academic language development of EALs. These standards are essential for helping EALs acquire the language skills necessary for success in school.

Enrolment in the EAL Support and Intervention

Students who are identified for EAL are supported through a comprehensive process that begins during the admission phase. New student's language proficiency is assessed throughout the welcome interview to support a smooth transition.

After enrolment, the EAL Teacher completes a mini-WIDA as a initial assessment of language skills. This determines next steps. Additional data is used to determine language support needs. Assessments may include; Measures of Academic Progress (MAP) tests, MAZE assessments, and Oral Reading Fluency (ORF) evaluations, phonic screeners, which help gauge students' reading abilities and comprehension skills.

Based on the universal screeners above, the EAL Specialists will decide if the WIDA MODEL assessments are utilized to provide a more detailed understanding of students' language proficiency across the four modalities: listening, speaking, reading, and writing. By combining these various data points, educators can effectively identify students who require targeted EAL support, ensuring that their specific language development needs are met for academic success.

Structure of EAL Support

WIDA MODEL Writing Rubric GRADES 1-12			
Level	Linguistic Complexity	Vocabulary Usage	Language Control
6 Reaching	A variety of sentence lengths of varying linguistic complexity in a single tightly organized paragraph or in well-organized extended text; tight cohesion and organization.	Consistent use of just the right word in the just the right place; precise Vocabulary Usage in general, specific, or technical language.	Has reached comparability to that of English proficient peers functioning at the "proficient" level in state-wide assessments.
5 Bridging	A variety of sentence lengths of varying linguistic complexity in a single organized paragraph or in extended text; cohesion and organization.	Usage of technical language related to the content area; evident facility with needed vocabulary.	Approaching comparability to that of English proficient peers; errors don't impede comprehensibility.
4 Expanding	A variety of sentence lengths of varying linguistic complexity; emerging cohesion used to provide detail and clarity.	Usage of specific and some technical language related to the content area; lack of needed vocabulary may be occasionally evident.	Generally comprehensible at all times, errors don't impede the overall meaning; such errors may reflect first language interference.
3 Developing	Simple and expanded sentences that show emerging complexity used to provide detail.	Usage of general and some specific language related to the content area; lack of needed vocabulary may be evident.	Generally comprehensible when writing in sentences; comprehensibility may from time to time be impeded by errors when attempting to produce more complex text.
2 Emerging	Phrases and short sentences; varying amount of text may be copied or adapted; some attempt at organization may be evidenced.	Usage of general language related to the content area; lack of vocabulary may be evident.	Generally comprehensible when text is adapted from model or source text, or when original text is limited to simple text; comprehensibility may be often impeded by errors.
1 Entering	Single words, set phrases or chunks of simple language; varying amounts of text may be copied or adapted; adapted text contains original language.	Usage of highest frequency vocabulary from school setting and content areas.	Generally comprehensible when text is copied or adapted from model or source text; comprehensibility may be significantly impeded in original text.

Mainstream Classroom & Support

Phase 2 = push in support / intervention groups

Phase 1 = pull out EAL class

Phase 1 EALs

Phase 1 EALs are students with a WIDA literacy score of 3.0 and below. These students often require targeted instruction to support their development of social and instructional language. The focus for Phase 1 students includes:

- **Speaking and Listening:** Activities that promote oral language skills through structured conversations, role-playing, and interactive discussions. These help students practice vocabulary and sentence structures in context.
- **Reading:** Instruction is tailored to build foundational reading skills, including phonemic awareness, decoding, and comprehension strategies. Teachers may use simplified texts and visual aids to enhance understanding.
- **Writing:** Emphasis is placed on developing basic writing skills, such as sentence formation and organization of ideas. Teachers provide guided writing exercises and use sentence frames to support student expression.

In Grade 5 Phase 1 students, daily Chinese language class is replaced with EAL English to support the acceleration of students' English development.

Phase 2 EALs

Phase 2 EALs are students with a WIDA literacy score between 3.0 and 4.0. These students have a stronger grasp of language and receive additional support through:

- **In-Class Support:** Teachers provide differentiated instruction within the regular classroom setting, allowing Phase 2 EALs to engage with grade-level content while receiving the necessary language support.
- **Reading and Writing Intervention Groups:** These groups focus on targeted interventions to enhance reading comprehension and writing skills. Students participate in small-group activities that address specific areas of need, such as vocabulary development, text analysis, and writing conventions.

By identifying the specific needs of Phase 1 and Phase 2 EALs, educators can implement targeted strategies that foster both language acquisition and academic success. This structured support helps students build confidence and develop the skills necessary to thrive in an English-speaking educational environment.

Using the WIDA framework to teach English Language Learners (EALs) in elementary school can be highly effective when integrated with the content from Readers and Writers units and Units of Inquiry (UOI). Here's how this can be accomplished:

Integrating WIDA with Readers and Writers Units

1. **Focus on Academic Language:**
 - a. In Readers and Writers units, emphasize the academic language specific to reading and writing. Incorporate vocabulary, sentence structures, and discourse practices that are relevant to the texts being studied. This helps EALs develop the language skills necessary for comprehension and expression.
2. **Scaffold Instruction:**

- a. Use scaffolding strategies to support EALs at different proficiency levels. For example, provide graphic organizers, sentence frames, and visual aids to help students organize their thoughts in writing and make connections while reading.
- 3. Collaborative Learning:**
- a. Encourage collaborative activities such as partner reading, peer editing, and group discussions. This fosters a supportive environment where EALs can practice their language skills in a low-stress setting.
- 4. Diverse Texts:**
- a. Select a variety of texts that reflect diverse cultures and experiences. This not only engages EALs but also allows them to relate their own backgrounds to the content, enhancing comprehension and motivation.

Integrating WIDA with Units of Inquiry (UOI)

- 1. Inquiry-Based Learning:**
- a. Utilize inquiry-based learning to engage EALs in exploring topics that interest them. This approach encourages questioning and critical thinking, which are vital for language development.
- 2. Language Objectives:**
- a. Set clear language objectives alongside content objectives for each UOI. For example, if the unit focuses on ecosystems, include goals for students to use specific vocabulary related to the topic, engage in discussions about their findings, and write reflective pieces.
- 3. Multimodal Learning:**
- a. Incorporate multimodal resources, such as videos, images, and hands-on activities, to support different learning styles. This helps EALs access content more effectively while developing their language skills.
- 4. Reflection and Assessment:**
- a. Encourage students to reflect on their learning through journals, discussions, and presentations. Use formative assessments to gauge language progress and adjust instruction accordingly.

By leveraging the WIDA framework within Readers and Writers units and Units of Inquiry, educators can create a rich, inclusive learning environment that supports the language development of EALs. This integrated approach not only enhances academic achievement but also fosters a sense of belonging and confidence among students.

Phase 1 Lesson Structure

While WIDA Standards drive our units, we instruct using Balanced Literacy **every day**. The required components of workshop consist of a structured mini-lesson, independent work time and share/closing.

Component	Teacher Role	Student Role	Time Guidelines
Language Activator	Visuals Teaching Methods: • Read alouds • Speaking activities • Phonemic Drills	Listen, think, talk	5-10 min
Mini-Lesson / Guided Practice Connection Teach Active Engagement Link	Anchor Charts Teaching Methods: • Demonstration: ◦ Mentor texts ◦ Using own writing • Guided Practice • Example and Explain • Inquiry	Listen, think, talk Participate in guided practice	20 min
Independent Work Time Independent reading/writing Conferences Small Group work Talk	Conference and confer with students one on one at their tables Confer using a tool kit Teach small groups (strategy lessons, guided reading, etc.)	Independently read books of their choosing, at levels that are accessible Independently write topics of their choosing Independently solve problems, use tools & charts for support, and	10 min

Partner Time: read books together and talk about the book	Teachers will confer with responsive small groups (based on informal and formal data)	use strategies taught in the unit.	
Share/Closing Partner work Teacher closing	Recap learning Extend learning New learning	Share with partners or class Reflect on day's work Participate in extension work	5-10 min

Phase 2 Interventions

Writing and Reading Intervention Groups for WIDA Developing Level Students

For WIDA Developing level students (typically with literacy scores between 3.0 and 4.0), writing and reading intervention groups can be highly effective when integrated with the content from Readers and Writers units. These groups are designed to support language development while enhancing literacy skills.

The intervention groups are devised by MAP, ORF, MAZE and phonics screeners and aim to target language goals in each student's individual language plan. The intervention groups use existing school endorsed resources such as UFLI, Patterns of Power, Morpheme Magic and scaffolding and graphic organizers from TCRWP.

Writing Intervention Groups

1. Focus on Structure and Organization:

- a. Teach students how to structure their writing, including the use of topic sentences, supporting details, and conclusions. Use graphic organizers to help them plan their writing.

2. Sentence Expansion and Variety:

- a. Encourage students to expand their sentences by adding adjectives, adverbs, and clauses. This helps them develop more complex sentence structures, which are crucial for academic writing.

3. Writing Workshops:

- a. Conduct writing workshops where students draft, revise, and share their work. Provide targeted feedback that focuses on both content and language use, guiding them to improve their writing skills.

4. Modeling and Guided Practice:

- a. Model various writing genres (e.g., narratives, informational texts) and provide examples from the Readers and Writers units. Use shared writing exercises to practice together before students write independently.

5. Vocabulary Development:

- a. Integrate vocabulary instruction that is relevant to the writing tasks. Introduce academic and domain-specific vocabulary that students can use in their writing.

Reading Intervention Groups

1. **Phonics**

Teach specific phonological and phonemic skills using the UFLI program.

2. **Comprehension Strategies:**

Teach specific reading comprehension strategies, such as predicting, questioning, summarizing, and inferring. Use think-alouds to model how to apply these strategies while reading.

3. **Close Reading:**

Engage students in close reading of selected texts, encouraging them to analyze language, identify key ideas, and make connections to their own experiences. This deepens their understanding of the text.

4. **Discussion and Collaboration:**

Facilitate discussions around the texts to promote oral language development. Encourage students to share their thoughts, ask questions, and engage in collaborative learning experiences.

5. **Vocabulary Building:**

Focus on vocabulary development related to the texts being read. Use word walls, flashcards, and interactive activities to reinforce new vocabulary in context.

By implementing targeted writing and reading intervention groups for WIDA Developing level students, educators can effectively support language and literacy development. Integrating the Readers and Writers units as content not only enhances engagement but also provides a rich framework for students to practice and apply their skills in meaningful ways. This approach fosters both academic success and confidence in using English in various contexts.

Balanced Literacy: Components

Component	
Read Aloud	- Think aloud - Gradual release to students

Teachers read aloud a text and purposely stop to practice a skill	- Pre-read the book and plan places to stop and think aloud and/or invite students to practice skills - Interactive, mentor texts, and for enjoyment
Shared Reading Teacher and students read an enlarged text together explicitly modeling the skills and strategies of proficient readers	- Effective way to meet students' needs in small group setting - Same text for 2-3 day cycle with a different focus each day
Guided Reading	Responsive small groups used to support students with the intention of developing reading skills as determined by data.
Strategy-based small group reading	Responsive small groups determined by teachers to meet a need for specific students
Interactive Writing A time when students and teacher co-create a text and share the pen	Teacher has focus in mind (e.g. word work, punctuation)
Shared Writing Students and teachers co-create a text based on a shared experience	Teacher does the writing with student input on content from readers, writers or UOI
Modeled Writing Teacher thinks aloud and models writing	Teacher demonstrates their thought process while writing
Phonic/Word Work	Direct phonetic and syntax instruction - UFLI - Morpheme Magic (3-5) - Patterns of Wonder or Patterns of Power
Weekly Memo	Email sent home on Friday to provide a preview of the following week's key vocabulary, concepts, and activities for the upcoming week. It also includes additional resources and links to enhance home learning.

Word Work Components	
Phonological Awareness (UFLI)	Sound structure of words
Phonics and SpEALing (UFLI)	Letter sound relationships and spelling patterns

High Frequency Words	The ability to read and write words that appear frequently in texts – Fry's 1000 words
Word Meaning and Vocabulary (Morpheme Magic)	Developing a complex understanding of words and their meaning
Word Structure (Morpheme Magic)	Using the structures of words to learn how words relate to each other (e.g. syllable knowledge, suffix knowledge, etc.)
Word-Solving Actions (Morpheme Magic)	When readers and writers use their language knowledge to solve words (e.g. using what you know to solve words, using roots to determine meaning, etc.)
Grammar (Patterns of Wonder, Patterns of Power)	Using the conventions and mechanics of standard English when writing and speaking

Assessment

A vital part of language interventions is to use data to know where students are and to drive instructional decisions and practices. While homeroom teachers use many methods of assessment in the classroom, there are EAL assessments that are used to monitor progress and screen for targeted interventions.

Assessment
Anecdotal Records - Ongoing throughout the EAL Class or Intervention - Conference notes
On-Demand & Published Writing (G1-5) - <u>On Demand</u>: Prompted writing piece, completed in one sitting, that shows students' writing ability with complete independence. - Pieces can be graded with a common rubric or WIDA writing rubric to inform instructional practices and show growth
Phonics Assessment - Assessing for phonemic knowledge and understanding - Administer the CORE phonics assessment to all phase 1 and phase 2 students. - PAST
WIDA MODEL - Assessing four language domains; speaking, listening, reading and writing. - Grade 1 Semester 2 to Grade 5

- EAL Teacher supports Math accommodation; text to speech (Math only) and alternative seating (students with complex learning needs or known learning diversity).
Running Records - Fluency assessment and reading comprehension. - UNLI Unit Assessments – Fluency Check - Phase 1 - UFLI passages and PM - Phase 2 – UFLI passages and PROBE - Can be completed on student lead texts and texts connected to UOI
Encoding - UFLI words
MAP Reading Fluency • Identify students who need targeted support for oral reading fluency and comprehension • Use the reports to form small groups based on actual reading skill gaps, not just overall reading level • Link assessment data to targeted, repeated practice so students get the right next step each time • Monitor growth over time to see which skills are improving and which need re-teaching or different scaffolds

Support

Head of Student Services, Learning Support Specialists and Assistant-Principal (AP) support EAL Teachers to create the best literacy instruction, interventions and learning environment for students. Head of Student Services, Learning Support Specialists and Assistant-Principal support EAL teachers through curriculum planning, examination of student and grade level data, team collaboration, and professional development.

Resources for Supporting EAL Learners

Resource Name	Description	How to Use to Support EAL Learners
Raz-Kids	An online leveled reading platform with interactive eBooks and quizzes.	- Assign leveled reading materials to match students' proficiency. - Use the "Listen, Read, and Record" feature to develop fluency and comprehension. - Monitor progress through quizzes and teacher reports.
BrainPOP	Educational videos and activities covering various academic subjects.	- Use videos to introduce complex topics in accessible ways. - Reinforce vocabulary and concepts through quizzes and activities. - Facilitate class discussions and projects using related resources.
BrainPOP Jr.	Simplified educational videos and activities for younger learners.	- Provide age-appropriate content for foundational concepts. - Support comprehension with visual aids and animations. - Use games and interactive activities to make learning engaging.
BrainPOP EAL	Animated videos and activities for teaching English as an additional language.	- Use videos to introduce new vocabulary and concepts. - Engage students in interactive games and quizzes for reinforcement. - Provide differentiated assignments based on language proficiency.
Epic!	A digital library with thousands of books and multimedia resources.	- Assign books that align with student interests and reading levels. - Use "Read-to-Me" books for listening practice. - Create personalized reading lists for independent practice.
Magic School	An AI-based resource that provides both teachers and students with an array of ready-made tools.	- Use AI-powered tools to create custom activities and assessments. - Monitor progress through interactive dashboards and reports. - Great resource for creating word banks, sentence frames, exemplars, etc.

ReadWorks.org	A reading comprehension platform with leveled texts and question sets.	- Assign leveled passages to build comprehension skills. - Use paired texts to explore themes and vocabulary. - Incorporate comprehension questions to assess understanding and develop critical thinking.
Lalilo	A phonics-based adaptive reading program.	- Strengthen foundational reading skills like phonics and sight words. - Assign practice on decoding, comprehension, and fluency. - Track student progress with real-time reports.
Seesaw	A digital portfolio platform for student-teacher communication and assignments.	- Assign speaking and writing activities for students to record responses. - Provide audio and visual instructions to scaffold assignments. - Share student work with parents to foster home-school collaboration.
Quizlet	A flashcard app for vocabulary practice and language learning.	- Create flashcard sets for academic and high-frequency vocabulary. - Use interactive games and practice modes to reinforce word meanings. - Encourage students to create their own flashcards for personalized learning.
Padlet	An interactive digital wall for collaborative learning.	- Use for brainstorming activities to build background knowledge. - Encourage collaborative writing and vocabulary building. - Share multimedia resources like videos, images, and links to support language learning.
Google Translate	A multilingual translation tool.	- Use for quick word or phrase translation. - Encourage translanguaging to help students access content in their home language. - Pair with classroom activities to reinforce English vocabulary and grammar.

Duolingo for Schools	A gamified language learning app.	- Assign daily practice for vocabulary and grammar. - Use as a supplemental tool for self-paced language acquisition. - Encourage students to set language goals and track their own progress.
Wordwall		EAL learners can practice key vocabulary, listening/reading, and spelling in low-pressure, visual formats; tasks can be tailored to specific language targets (e.g., topic words, sentence starters, grammar focus), and activities can be repeated for confidence and fluency.